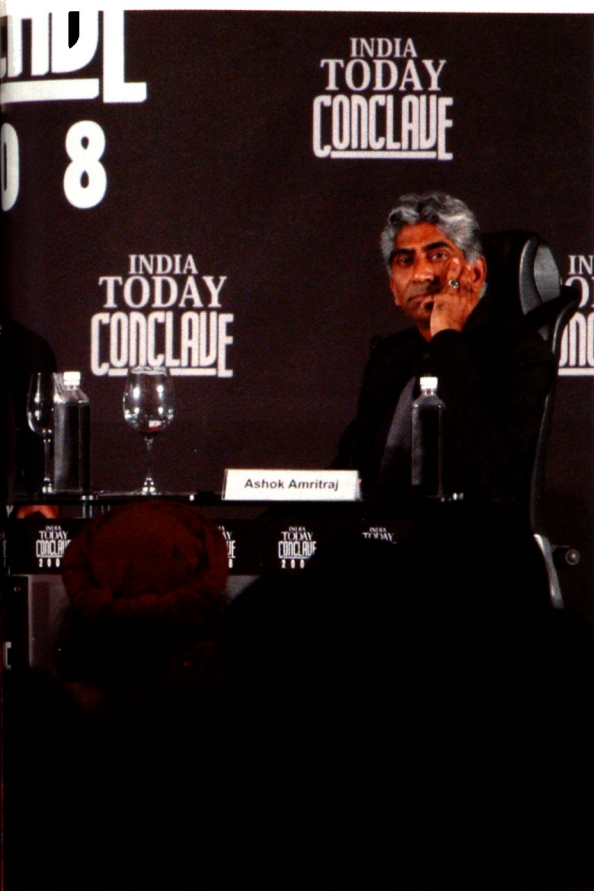




"CORPORATES WILL HAVE TO INVEST TIME, ENERGY AND MONEY INTO CREATIVE PEOPLE."

Aamir Khan

India is at a crossroads where many directors and producers are making ten movies for some corporate company or the other and there seems to be too much money chasing too few good movies. Corporatisation is good for the business but people in the organisations have to care about the movies they are making. You have to be involved. My company is presented a thousand projects a year. We end up developing 10 but we make only four. We finance our films, distribute them internationally and it's just in the US and Canada that the studios distribute the films for me. The studio is the gatekeeper right now. But will that change the whole movie experience? I would never wish it to go away. On a Friday night, kids go out to the movie theatre with their bag of popcorn. I did it when I was an eight-year-old watching the *The Sound of Music*. I do it now and will do it always.

make it easier for content makers to have their talent seen across the world for people like myself sitting in Los Angeles. As for India, there is an extraordinary amount of talent in front of and behind the camera. I think the younger filmmakers have started making more diverse and different films. The distribution is a little bit of a dichotomy. While the foreign market grows, I think the methods of distribution are old fashioned. Indian films in the US are screened in about a 100 theatres primarily for the NRIs. Can we just say that Bollywood hasn't been given the shock that it should be given? Aamir's *Lagaan* pleased the core audience but also had that spark that made it very interesting for a western audience. Yet, it was badly distributed outside India.

D I S C U S S I O N

Q. I have heard that over 90 per cent of films go bust. What then is your advice to the corporate sector?

Khan: Actually a lot of films are increasingly doing better. The entertainment business is growing a lot, the theatres are growing in numbers and I think that will dramatically increase the revenues for Indian films. I think if you are investing in a corporate or you have a corporation of your own, which intends to make films, it is really important for you to invest time, energy and money into people who have a creative bent but who may not necessarily direct films for you. As a producer,

if I am able to pick a script and say yes this is what I want to make, he is directing it, he is acting in it, this is the team, I put them together and I set them at sail. You need people who are really sharp and young with the spirit of adventure. Because films are different from other products. Other products when they do well, you have to recreate them again and again, but in films, each time, the product has to be different. You need a team that is able to recognise talent and put teams together. So much of it is people management. That is why the Hollywood strike happened. I remember telling A.R. Rahman years ago that in the near future his

greatest revenue stream would be from the download. I told him, you will spend hours getting exactly the right notes and people are going to hear it for all of 30 seconds as a ringtone. I actually call people who have nice ringtones, so I can listen to them at leisure. Also, if you select a bunch of people who are really young and dynamic, you should send them to film schools for short courses. They may not ever make a film. But they have to understand what it is to make a film.

Q. Why are you working so hard to create couch potatoes and make the films smaller and accessible on the iPod, instead of getting more people

into the theatres?

Amritraj: It is about what the consumer wants. Will the consumer even have two and a half hours to spend with you? The generation of interactivity is looking upon entertainment in a completely different way. In the West, they force you to raise the quality of your films because you are competing against video games, Internet, and the iPod. You should know how to market films in a way that it stands out amongst the other five films opening on a Friday.

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